

Crews left site despite hot spot

As in Palisades, an earlier fire sparked a larger one in Ventura County last year.

By RICHARD WINTON

A fire that burned nearly 250 homes and structures in Ventura County was a rekindling of an earlier blaze that firefighters failed to fully extinguish, according to an investigation by Ventura County fire officials and prosecutors released Friday.

The findings, announced at a news conference, put more focus on the tactics firefighters use in declaring blazes out, especially after authorities concluded that the destructive Palisades fire was a restart of a Jan. 1 fire that the Los Angeles Fire Department wrongly declared fully extinguished.

The failure in Los Angeles to put out the Jan. 1 fire has led to outrage and a federal investigation.

In the case of the Ventura County fire, fire officials said they knew there were hot spots from a tractor that ignited the blaze, but did not think they would cause any problems.

During the news conference, Ventura County Fire Chief Dustin Gardner revealed the Mountain fire came back to life, most likely because hot rubber from a burned tractor tire was picked up by extreme winds and carried into dry tinder, where the fire started anew.

About a week before the Mountain fire started on Nov. 6, 2024, a tractor caught fire in Somis while clearing brush, officials said. Firefighters responded, along with a C-130 air tanker, and together they held the fire known as the Balcom fire to 1.8 acres and declared it out after three hours at 6 p.m.

Gardner said more than 100 firefighters used hoses to put a “wet line” around the fire perimeter, while bulldozers cut away vegetation in its path and aircraft caked the ground with retardant. Then, firefighters with hand tools and infrared technology checked the area for heat.

The next day, officials said, crews flew a drone that can see hot spots over the area and detected heat near the fire’s edge and the tractor wheels. Firefighters went to those areas and dug out the smoldering material so it could cool, officials said.

Although the temperature around the wheels of the tractor was registering at 300 degrees, Gardner said that’s not unusual for equipment caught in a fire.

“Heat in a burnt-out tractor, a burnt-out carcass of steel ... that is not alarming, that’s not out of the ordinary,” Gardner said.

“As an example, if you look at a tailpipe right now going in the parking lot, it would be more than 500 de-



CHRISTINA HOUSE Los Angeles Times

MARSHA TAULTON, right, waits for a flight home to Houston at LAX on Friday. Passengers were warned that flights could be canceled with little notice.

Fliers scramble as cuts begin; pain will grow

Cancellations to rise as shutdown persists. Nation’s controllers are taking side jobs.

By JENNY JARVIE, SUHAUNA HUSSAIN, KAREN GARCIA AND HANNAH FRY

Travelers got their first taste of what is expected to be worsening cuts in commercial air traffic due to the government shutdown, bringing delays, anxiety and confusion to airports across the nation.

By some measures, the level of chaos was less than some feared, but government officials warned that flight cancellations are set to increase over the next few days.

According to an emergency order released by the Trump administration, airlines had to cut flights by 4% on Friday and then ramp up to 6% by Tuesday, 8% by Thursday and 10% by Nov. 14. The administration said that number could rise to 20% if the shutdown continues.

Lauren Chavez had scrolled through horror story after horror story on TikTok

about the government shutdown leading to long delays and cancellations at U.S. airports, with people camping out in terminals for hours.

Out of an abundance of caution, the 28-year-old had arrived at Los Angeles International Airport — her fiancé and 4-year-old daughter in tow — six hours early for their 3:55 p.m. Southwest flight back home to Albuquerque.

But all was relatively quiet Friday as she sat cross-legged in bustling Terminal 1 after a few days at Disneyland and California Adventure.

Besides a few flights delayed by 30 minutes to an hour, most appeared to be running on schedule.

“We anticipated long TSA lines,” Chavez said as her daughter clambered into her lap, watching a video on her mom’s phone, as people checked in for flights around them.

[See **Fliers**, A12]

As Thanksgiving nears, GOP frets

Party faces pressure to end shutdown as flights are canceled and federal workers miss checks. **A2**

GOP risks losing gains with Latinos

WASHINGTON — President Trump made historic gains with Latinos when he won reelection last year, boosting Republicans’ confidence that their economic message was helping them make inroads with a group of voters who had long leaned toward Democrats.

But in this week’s election, Democrats in key states were able to disrupt that rightward shift by gaining back Latino support, exit polls showed.

In New Jersey and Virginia, the Democrats running for governor made gains in counties with large Latino populations, and overall won two-thirds of the Latino vote in their states, according to an NBC

Election results show economic concerns may make Trump’s success last year fleeting

By Ana Ceballos and Andrea Castillo

News poll.

And in California, a CNN exit poll showed about 70% of Latinos voting in favor of Proposition 50, a Democratic redistricting initiative designed to counter Trump’s plans to reshape congressional maps in an effort to keep GOP control of the House.

The results mark the first concrete example at the ballot box of Latino voters turning away from the GOP — a shift foreshadowed by recent polling as their concerns about the economy and immigration raids have grown.

If the trend continues, it could spell

[See **Latinos**, A6]

Mamdani buoys L.A. democratic socialists

After New York win, organizers are hoping to add two more City Council seats in June.

By DAVID ZAHNISER

The revelers who packed Tuesday’s election night party in L.A.’s Highland Park neighborhood were roughly 2,500 miles from the concert hall where New York City Mayor-elect Zohran Mamdani celebrated his historic win.

Yet despite that sprawling distance, the crowd, heavily populated with members of the L.A. chapter of Democratic Socialists of



ERIC THAYER Los Angeles Times

AN ELECTION night party in Highland Park co-hosted by Democratic Socialists of America-L.A.

9/11 POSTS: Backlash follows after D.A. shared 2001 images with anti-Mamdani comments. **CALIFORNIA, B1**

America, had no trouble finishing the applause lines delivered by Mamdani, himself a DSA member, during his victory speech.

“New York!” Mamdani bellowed on the oversized television screens hung throughout the Greyhound Bar & Grill. “We’re going to make buses fast and — “

“Free!” the crowd inside the bar yelled back in response.

In Los Angeles, activists with the Democratic Socialists of America have already fired up their campaigns for the June election, sending out canvassing teams and scheduling postcard-writing events for their chosen candidates. But they’re also

[See **Socialists**, A6]

JAMES WATSON, 1928 – 2025

Nobel winner, DNA pioneer

Scientist decoded the structure of life, left legacy that changed biology and medicine.

By JOHN JOHNSON

On a chilly February afternoon in 1953, a gangly American and a fast-talking Brit walked into the Eagle pub in Cambridge, England, and announced to the assembled imbibers that they had discovered the “secret of life.”

Even by the grandiose standards of bar talk, it was a provocative statement. Except, it was also pretty close to the truth. That morning, James Watson, the American whiz kid who had not yet turned 25, and his British colleague, Francis Crick, finally had worked out the structure of DNA.

Everything that followed, unlocking the human genome, learning to edit and move genetic information to cure disease and create new forms of life, the revolution in criminal justice with DNA fingerprinting, and many other things besides, grew out of the discovery of the double-helix shape of DNA.

It took Watson decades to feel worthy of a breakthrough some consider the equal of Einstein’s famous $E=MC^2$ formula. But he got there. “Did Francis and I deserve the double helix?” Watson asked rhetorically, 40 years later. “Yeah, we did.”

James Dewey Watson, Nobel Prize winner and “semi-professional loose cannon” whose racist views made him a scientific pariah late in life, died Thursday in hospice care after a brief illness, according to officials at his former lab, Cold Spring Harbor Laboratory. He was 97.

Born April 6, 1928 in Chicago, he was the son of a bill

[See **Watson**, A5]

A 10-year-old’s fight for his bees

After city complaint, campaign saves a backyard colony

Sometimes it takes a village to raise a child. Or for one 10-year-old in Northern California, a colony of bees.

When the city of Santa Rosa received an anonymous complaint this year about some problem insects in the area, city officials looked into the matter and zeroed in on the Bard family home and, in particular, its colony of thousands of European bees.

As it turned out, keeping the bees was considered an “occupation,” even for a child, and Nicholas Bard and his parents were in violation. The bees, the city said, had to go.

At first, the family appealed and thought they



KENT PORTER Press Democrat

NICHOLAS BARD’s family received a complaint over their backyard bees.

found a sympathetic ear after speaking with a city worker, who told the family they’d run the issue up the chain to their boss.

“We thought we’ll get all of this rectified,” said Nicholas’ mother, Sara Bard.

Instead, the city’s response stung. The supervisor informed the Bards that they were not only in violation of having a home business, but also possibly looking at a second ding for having nuisance insects on their property.

“I was pretty sad and they were sad too,” Nicholas said, referring to his parents but also his bees. “When I told them, you can hear how

[See **Bees**, A8]

YouTube-Disney fight may drag on

Cost of sports rights fees and other factors have fueled video platform’s disputes with media companies. **BUSINESS, A10**

Will Rogers park set to reopen

Despite serious damage from the Palisades fire, the hiking oasis will make a partial comeback. **CALIFORNIA, B1**

Weather
Sunny.
L.A. Basin: 82/60. **B8**

Markets **A12**

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